ALAN MOORE: THE SCORE Moore info

// Born 18 November, 1953

// Aged 17, Moore is kicked out of school for dealing LSD.

// Moore spends the next several years in menial jobs before embarking on a career as a cartoonist in the late Seventies, producing strips for *Sounds* magazine under the name Curt Vile.

// Eventually concentrating on writing, Moore provides work for *Marvel UK*, *Warrior* and *2000AD*, producing such celebrated work as *Captain Britain*, *Marvelman*, *V For Vendetta*, *The Ballad Of Halo Jones* and *D.R. & Quinch*.

// 1983: Enters the US industry with pioneering work on DC Comics' *Swamp Thing*.

// 1986-1987: *Watchmen* released in the US, which cements Moore's superstar reputation.

// Dissatisfied with creator's lack of rights, Moore withdraws from the mainstream industry in the late Eighties, preferring to align with small, indie publishers. Here, he starts two major projects that would not be completed for many years: *From Hell* and *Lost Girls*.

// 1989: Moore's *V For Vendetta*, originally published in *Warrior* comic (but never completed), is published in a collected edition.

// 1993: Moore returns to the mainstream writing an issue of Todd McFarlane's best-selling *Spawn* for Image Comics. He stays with Image, writing the series *Supreme*, *Youngblood* and *Glory*.

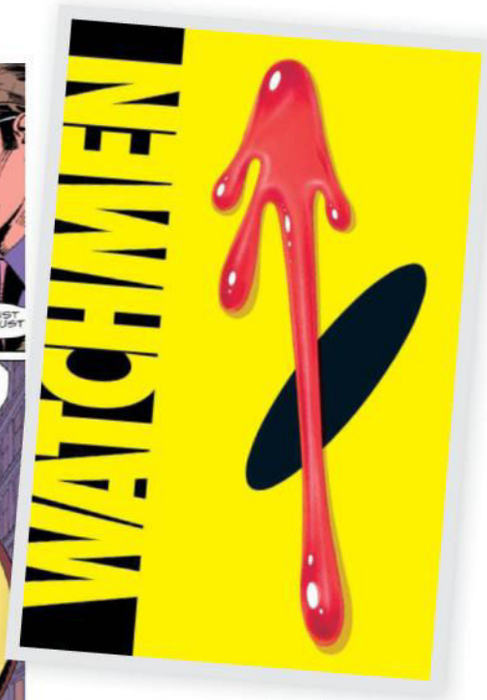
// 1998: *From Hell*, Moore's metaphysical assessment of Jack The Ripper is finally published in its complete form. It is widely considered one of Moore's best works.

// 1999: Moore sets up the 'America's Best Comics' imprint with Jim Lee's Wildstorm Comics (later bought by DC). Moore's output becomes prolific, writing *Tom Strong*, *Promethea*, *Tomorrow Stories*, *League Of Extraordinary Gentlemen* and *Top 10*.

// 2006: After 16 years and numerous publishers, the pornographic *Lost Girls* is finally released in the USA to remarkably little controversy. Thanks to copyright issues over *Peter Pan*, the book will hit UK stores on 1 Jan 2008.



Twenty years on and *Watchmen* has lost none of its appeal.



The tone of the piece perfectly suited Dave Gibbons' art.



that comics could do that cinema couldn't, and to show off the things that comics could do that literature couldn't.

Warren Ellis has asserted that comics is one of the last places where you can have a soapbox to rant upon about things that are relatively free of constraint. It could be said there are elements of that in *Watchmen*. Do you agree?

Certainly. I was a lot younger then and a lot 'rantier'. With *Watchmen*, I was able to use the hero icons to play a kind of chess game, where I could consider ideas of absolute power, in an abstract sense, but embodied in these big characters. What marks my work these days is that I feel less inclined to preach in the same way that I did then. That's not to say that I don't deal with issues that don't concern me. I don't always feel that they are best expressed in a superhero comic.

Watchmen spearheaded the sudden popularity of 'graphic novels', but that surge ultimately failed to sustain itself. Why do you think this was?

After *Watchmen*, one of the things I deplored most about the comics industry was that everything was in the hands of the marketing people, who, very often, had no idea of the comics industry at all... they'd just been marketing people for another company and got a job with a comics company and then would be bringing in their half-arsed ideas. When comics in the mid-Eighties seemed as if they had finally reached their Xanadu, we were getting attention from outside the medium, where comics actually looked like becoming an actual cultural phenomenon that would be enjoyed by everybody. What happened was that the marketing department saw it as a marketing opportunity, not a creative opportunity. So, after *Dark Knight*, *Watchmen*, and things that were worthy of serious attention, you've got this flood of so-called graphic novels that were just big, expensive comics. They completely devalued the entire medium.

Following such widespread deconstruction of the genre, do you think the time is right now to rediscover the magic of the superhero genre?

The alchemists used to have these two principles that they could more or less divide the entire universe up in to, and these were referred to as 'Solve et Coagula'. 'Solve' is to take something apart and examine it – it's analysis. 'Coagula' is to put it back together again – synthesis. Analysis and synthesis... Solve et Coagula... and to some degree, the analysis, this is deconstructionism. This is what we were doing with *Watchmen*. I remember when I was a child, and there would be old wristwatches that had been abandoned and left in the sideboard drawer, and if you got permission from your Mum and Dad, you could perhaps get an old screwdriver and start to take them apart, take all the little cogs out, which is why that perhaps turns up as a motif in the Dr Manhattan stuff in *Watchmen*. It's very easy to take things apart, even if you do it in an elaborate way, like *Watchmen*. Taking apart the conceptual apparatus of the superhero... it's not exactly rocket science... but putting it all back together again in a more benign and more transcendent form that works – a more flexible form, a better, improved form – that is something which is a little bit more tricky.

For you, where does *Watchmen* rank in your comics work?

Watchmen will always be very special to me because it was a real breakthrough in terms of technique. It was really quite ground-breaking – there was a range of techniques that Dave and I developed specifically for the book – but by the time I finished *Watchmen*, they already felt like a cliché to me. It has a lot of emotional depth that I was extremely pleased with. I love the convolution of *Watchmen* – it is a lovely Swiss watch piece.